

War on the Ho Chi Minh Trail

The United States waged war on the Ho Chi Minh Trail for years, without success. For every high-tech method it deployed, the Vietnamese people maintaining and using the trail found an effective and often ingenious workaround—albeit at tremendous human cost.

◀◀ BEFORE

Past experience had taught the North Vietnamese and Viet Cong the importance of an effective supply line.

DEVELOPING THE TRAIL

During the war against the French, Viet Minh leaders in the mountains of the Laotian and Chinese border regions struggled to maintain contact with forces further south. To do so, they relied on a **network of footpaths** through the Truong Son Mountains. A generation later, when North Vietnam moved to a war footing, Colonel Vo Bam developed **a trail system** to supply the southern insurgents with war materiel and move fighters into the South.

The Ho Chi Minh Trail was not a single trail, but rather a network of trails and roads that eventually reached 12,000 miles (19,300 km) in length. The trail varied in condition and sophistication over the years. Rustic paths, treacherous bamboo staircases, and rope bridges traversed by porters pushing bicycles gave way, by the early 1970s, to one-lane roads and bridges able to carry truck traffic.

Working the trail

North Vietnam deployed about 75,000 civilians to maintain the trail, including boys and girls in their teens. These Youth Volunteers could expect to spend time filling bomb craters, repairing bridges, and even detonating unexploded ordnance. They lived on the trail, deep in the jungle, generally sleeping by day, in hammocks or in underground bunkers, and coming out at night to work. The threat of bombing was constant and living conditions were harsh. When food was scarce, they foraged for cassava or even moss. Malaria, dysentery, and trench foot were rampant, and medical care was rudimentary or nonexistent. When the workers returned home at war's end, they were pale, hairless, and frail, with health problems that would plague them for the rest of their lives.

1,000 MILES (1,609 km) The distance some North Vietnamese soldiers marched to reach South Vietnam before the introduction of trucks.